

Methodological Journal 2

Successful African American professionals

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My initial interview with John was scheduled for October 12, 2007, but I had to cancel because I was sick that whole week. I contacted John and got another interview appointment with John. John was happy to reschedule and was more than willing to work around my schedule. I asked John if I could interview him over lunch. John agreed. I rescheduled our first interview for October 22, 2007.

On the day of the interview, I contacted John around 10 am to confirm our appointment and to set up a meeting place. John and I agreed to meet at Red Robin for lunch, a restaurant next to our office.

John and I met at Red Robin, ordered lunch, and talked about what was going on at Oracle. As our conversation settled down, I took out my digital voice recorder and started talking about it and its cool features. I had mentioned to John before about recording our conversation. John allowed me to use my digital voice recorder without any hesitation. Once again, I thanked John for agreeing to participate in this study. I reiterated that I planned to share the information with my colleagues at Ohlone. I told him that, based on the information from the interview, I hoped to raise awareness of the challenges facing African American (AA) students and students from underrepresented groups in educational settings.

My strategy for the first interview was to determine John's background, his family, siblings, and where he lives, as I had outlined in my interview protocol. I prepared a series of questions I wanted to answer. I reviewed the questions before interviewing John, and I pretty much knew ahead of time that I wouldn't get answers to all of them. I had a copy of the questions in my back pocket to keep me on track, and I wanted to present them in order. However, at the restaurant, I felt awkward about taking

the questions out, because I wanted to approach my interview with John as a casual conversation.

My first impression of John was that he dressed really nicely that day. He wore a creamy-colored dress shirt and tailored dress pants that went well with his black shoes. He looked great. Even though I just wanted to collect some data from him for my mini study, John seemed to be serious about it. I was not sure whether he dressed up for the interview or just wore his everyday clothes. Nevertheless, I liked it because John took our interview seriously and was professional. It seemed to me that John wanted to get his life story told. I was impressed with the way he introduced himself to me. It seemed to me that John was more than willing to share his life story with me and to answer my questions about his personal background. John was such a nice and pleasant guy to talk to.

The settings at Red Robin restaurant were also good. Red Robin was a good place for group gatherings and social conversation, and the food was great, too. There were a lot of customers sitting around us with their own conversation, but that did not seem to bother John. He talked most of the time about his life story from one thing to the next. John talked about many things—family, growing up in Nigeria, and then in this country. The waitress at Red Robin was the only person who interrupted us to take our lunch order and occasionally stopped by to ask if we needed anything else. She was nice as well.

Overall, I was satisfied with the outcome of the interview. The settings described above, not only John, but I too, felt comfortable with the interview process. For my first interview with John, I wanted to gather information about his background, profession,

and growing up. I did not get all the information as I had outlined for the first interview in my interview protocol. All in all, I collected the necessary data for my studies.

However, I was able to collect much of the information for both the second and first interviews. The questionnaires from the first interview, as outlined in my interview protocol, were collected for the items with strikethrough notation below (see interview transcript 1 for details). John had repeatedly mentioned to me that if I had any more questions, I should just send him an email or use the Internet chat (ping me).

Questionnaires for the first interview:

Casual Conversation

1. ~~What is your occupation?~~
2. ~~What is your employer's name?~~
3. What do you do there?
4. How long have you been working for _____?
5. What is your job title?
6. What primary function does your job involve?
7. How do you describe the organization that you work for?

Growing up

1. ~~What can you tell me about your learning experiences as you grew up?~~
2. ~~How was it like for you to learn in school?~~
3. Was there a class or activity in school that you enjoyed or disliked in particular?
Tell me about it.
4. What can you tell me about your relationships with peers, teachers, administrators, or family members that might have influenced your learning experiences in school?
5. ~~What other aspects of your life were linked to your learning experience in school?~~
6. ~~What can you tell me about your learning at home?~~
7. What other kinds of learning did you experience outside of school?
8. How were people or family members influential to your learning outside of school?

Early Adulthood

1. What kinds of learning did you experience when you left school?
2. ~~How did family members or other people influence your learning at this time?~~
3. What other factors influenced your learning experiences? Can you recall any specific situations or circumstances that you may have contributed to either your participation or lack of involvement in learning as a young adult?
4. ~~Is there anything else we should know about you?~~

Questionnaires for the second interview:

General Questions Relating to Family and Personal Views about Education

1. ~~Are you married?~~
2. What is your spouse's name?
3. ~~Do you have any kids? How many kids do you have?~~
4. Follow-up question: What do your kids like about school? What would your kid(s) like to be when they grow up? Where do your kids go to school (public or private)?
5. ~~Did you go to college? What college did you go to? How many years did you spend in college? Did you graduate? Why did you decide to go to college? Who paid your way through school?~~
6. What is the educational level of your spouse?
7. ~~What is the educational level of your father?~~
8. ~~What is the educational level of your mother?~~
9. ~~Do you have any siblings? How many brothers and sisters do you have? What is the educational level of your siblings?~~
10. What person influenced you to pursue education and a career?
11. ~~What are your educational goals?~~
12. ~~What are your beliefs about education?~~
13. Is there anything else about education that we have not talked about, but that you would like to share?